

Three Keowns in Blue

Nathan, John, and Thomas Keown of Missouri — a father and two sons, and the war that called them one by one

Built upon *A Life in War and Peace*, compiled by Robert Babcock, 2025, and expanded from original records
For the Keown–Schultz–Rawson–Babcock family

A line made for soldiering

Before the three Keowns of this story ever marched for the Union, their family had already given soldiers to two American wars. The line begins with **Thomas Keown**, born about 1742 in County Down, Ulster, who crossed to Virginia, landed at Charleston in 1771, and settled the South Carolina backcountry at Abbeville. When the Revolution came to the Ninety Six District, he served — and the paper survives. The Daughters of the American Revolution recognize him as **Patriot Ancestor A065094**, a militia soldier whose pay stub is still on file in the South Carolina archives, and thirty-four of his descendants have since proven their lines to join on his name.

His son **Nathan Lusk Keown** carried the family over the mountains into Kentucky — and in November 1814, a Private “Nathan Kown” appears on the roll of Captain Thomas Sterrett’s company of Kentucky Detached Militia, raised for the New Orleans campaign, with a William Kown beside him. The age, the county, and the brother’s name all fit our Nathan; the final proof awaits his service file, and we say so plainly. But the pattern was set either way: when the country called, Keown men went, and they went together.

The farm on the border

By 1860 the family’s Missouri branch was farming near the Iowa line, in the Greentop country of north Missouri. The census taker’s page — preserved in this family’s own research files — shows the household plainly:

1860 UNITED STATES CENSUS · MISSOURI		dwelling 1047 · family 850
HEAD	Nathan J. Keown · 45 · Farmer · born Kentucky	

WIFE	Mary A. · 44
SON	John H. · 15
SON	Thomas · 13
SON	William D. · 10
DAUGHTER	Nancy E. · 6
REAL/PERSONAL ESTATE	\$1,600 / \$1,345
BIRTHPLACES	Nathan through William D.: Kentucky (ditto marks) · Nancy E.: Missouri

The birthplace column tells the family’s road: every Keown down through ten-year-old William was born in **Kentucky** — in Ohio County, the obituaries later said, the same county where the wider Keown clan lived and died — and only little Nancy was born in Missouri. Sometime between about 1850 and 1854, Nathan moved his young family from the Kentucky hills to the Missouri border country. There they are, a year before the war reached them: **Nathan J. Keown**, Kentucky-born farmer of about forty-five; and two boys a bedroom apart in age — **John H.**, fifteen, and **Thomas**, thirteen. Missouri was a border state coming apart at the seams. Guerrilla raids, divided neighbors, and the constant talk of war — as the family’s compiled history puts it, this was the world a teenager grew into “during one of America’s most divisive eras.” The Keowns chose the Union, in a state where that choice could cost a family everything.

July 6, 1861: the father and the first son

The lore this family carried said the Keown men went to war together. The records, pulled from the Missouri State Archives in 2026, tell a story both earlier and harder. In the first summer of the war, Col. David Moore was raising his Northeast Missouri volunteers under a recruiting handbill that promised, “Secessionists and rebel traitors desiring a fight can be accommodated on demand.” On **July 6, 1861** — Fort Sumter not yet three months old — two Keowns enlisted at Adair County on the same day: **Nathan J. Keown**, the forty-six-year-old farmer, and his eldest son **John H.**, about sixteen.

RECORD OF SERVICE CARD · MISSOURI ADJ UTANT GENERAL	reel s00857, image 0802
NAME · RANK	Keown, Nathan J. · Sergeant, Co. B, 21st Reg’t Inf. Vols.
ENLISTED	July 6, ’61 — Adair Co., Mo.
MUSTERED IN	Feb. 1, ’62 — Canton, Mo.
REMARKS	Dis. Jan 30, ’63, at Mound City, Ill; disability

RECORD OF SERVICE
CARD · MISSOURI ADJ
UTANT GENERAL

reel s00857, image 0801

NAME · RANK	Keown, John H. · Corporal, Co. B, 21st Reg't Inf. Vols.
ENLISTED	July 6, '61 — Adair Co., Mo.
MUSTERED IN	Feb. 1, '62 — Canton, Mo.
REMARKS	Died Apr. 1, '62, of disease in Hosp. at Hannibal, Mo.

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21 Reg't Inf. Vols.

Keown, Nathan J. Age

Rank .. Sgt. Co. B. Captain .. Davis

Enlisted July 6, 61. Where .. Adair Co. Mo.

Mustered in Feb. 1, 62. Where .. Canton Mo.

Remarks Dis. Jan. 30, 62. at Mound City, Ill. disability

Mustered out

Where

Form No. 211, A. G. O., 7-1-00-16M

Nathan's card, Missouri State Archives

709 80

21 Reg't Inf. Vols.

Keown, John H. Age

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Enlisted July 6, 61. Where .. Adair Co. Mo.

Mustered in Feb. 1, 62. Where .. Canton Mo.

Remarks Died Apr. 1, 62. of disease in Hosp. at Hannibal Mo.

Mustered out

Where

Form No. 211, A. G. O., 7-1-00-16M

John's card — the clerk's last line tells everything

They were original Moore men — which means they were almost certainly in the ranks a month later at the **Battle of Athens** on the Des Moines River (August 5, 1861), where Moore's five hundred, carrying freshly issued Springfields, broke an attack by four times their number and finished it with a bayonet charge. (Their presence at Athens is a strong unit-level inference, not yet proven from muster rolls, and we say so.) That winter Moore's command was consolidated into the **21st Missouri Infantry**, and father and son mustered into Company B together at Canton on February 1, 1862 — Nathan with a sergeant's stripes, the rank companies gave their older, steady, locally respected original men; John a corporal at sixteen.

Hannibal, April 1862: the brother who never saw the front

From Canton the regiment marched to Hannibal and spent the late winter drilling in a cold, crowded camp. Orders for the front came March 28: to St. Louis, then by steamboat up the Tennessee to Pittsburg Landing, where Grant's army was gathering. John H. Keown was not aboard. He had sickened in the Hannibal camp, and on **April 1, 1862**, the sixteen-year-old corporal died of disease in the hospital there — the death that took more Civil War soldiers than all its battles combined. His service card closes in one clerk's line: "*Died Apr. 1, '62, of disease in Hosp. at Hannibal, Mo.*" He never saw the front he had drilled a year for.

Five days later, at dawn on April 6, his regiment opened the Battle of Shiloh.

Nathan's war: Shiloh to the breaking point

It stands in the regiment's own published history: the 21st Missouri was **the first Union infantry regiment engaged at Shiloh**. Sent forward at first light to sustain the driven-in pickets, Moore's men attacked the oncoming Confederate front line head-on; the colonel's leg was shattered by one of the first volleys, the major was killed, and by the end of it the regiment had lost 31 killed, 154 wounded, and 71 captured. Whether Sergeant Keown stood in the dawn line — and whether word from Hannibal had even reached him yet — is what his federal service file will say; the regiment's place in the story is beyond doubt.

What followed wore the survivors down as surely as battle: the month-long siege of Corinth; a summer guard camp at Chewalla, Tennessee, where smallpox ran seventy concurrent cases and killed more than thirty men; then an overnight forced march back to fight the **Battle of Corinth** (October 3–4, 1862) on the extreme left along the railroad, muskets fouling after fifteen or twenty rounds. By that autumn the 21st counted fewer than four hundred effectives of the thousand who had mustered. Winter outpost duty followed at Union City, Tennessee, building stockades against Forrest's raiders — and there the sergeant's health finally gave out. He was carried to the great Union hospital at **Mound City, Illinois**, a converted foundry complex on the Ohio nursed by the Sisters of the Holy Cross, and on **January 30, 1863**, discharged for disability. Nathan J. Keown had given the Union eighteen months, a full battle season, and a son.

November 1863: the third Keown

That is the household seventeen-year-old Thomas lived in through 1863: an older brother dead at Hannibal, a father home broken from the campaigns. That November he enlisted anyway — in **Company F of the 12th Missouri Cavalry**, a new regiment forming at Benton Barracks, St. Louis. The family's

compiled history remembered the father as “already a veteran of an earlier conflict” whose example stood behind his sons’ service; the records show the memory was true and then some. The earlier conflict was this same war, the example was paid in full, and the third Keown to wear blue now carried the family’s fight alone.

That winter Thomas learned the cavalryman’s trade outside St. Louis — the care of mounts, the carbine, the revolver, the saber; cold barracks, short rations, and relentless drill. The family history preserves the texture: recruits grooming horses for hours, repairing their own tack, sleeping beside their saddles. “For Thomas... it was a sharp contrast to the steady rhythms of Missouri farm life.”

The Twelfth rides south

Thomas’s regiment garrisoned St. Louis until June 1864, then moved down to Memphis, and in August rode A. J. Smith’s expedition into Mississippi — first blood on the Tallahatchie near Abbeville, then Holly Springs and Hurricane Creek, then the autumn pursuit of Forrest. The compiled history describes the texture truly: water scarce, rations irregular, dozens of miles a day through mud or dust, an enemy of organized forces and guerrilla bands alike who “struck from the woods or disappeared into the hills.” Many troopers slept with carbines within arm’s reach.

Then came the campaign that put the 12th Missouri at one of the war’s decisive moments. When Hood invaded Tennessee in November 1864, the regiment — riding in Hatch’s division of Wilson’s cavalry corps, under Gen. George H. Thomas — fought at Columbia and Spring Hill, and at the **Battle of Nashville** (December 15–16, 1864) lost 15 killed and 40 wounded on the first day alone while helping capture seven guns and some 250 prisoners, then rode the freezing pursuit that destroyed Hood’s army as a fighting force.

Family memory has long said Thomas “was with Sherman on his March to the Sea,” and here the records ask for an honest correction that gives more than it takes. In those exact weeks Sherman had split his forces: he took one army east to Savannah, and left the other under Gen. Thomas to destroy Hood in Tennessee. Thomas Keown rode with the second — and Nashville was the more complete victory of the two. Same winter, same grand campaign, opposite direction: the family folded the two halves into one and, without knowing it, kept the truer half. Friends recalled that in later years he spoke of those campaigns “with quiet humility, proud not of victory but of endurance.”

The shell

Somewhere in those southern campaigns, an artillery shell burst close enough to Thomas to tear open his head. The *Arroyo Grande Valley Herald-Recorder* put it plainly decades later: he “was wounded in the head by an exploding shell.” He survived it without modern medicine, carrying a scar for the rest of his

life — and it was likely in recovery, the family history judges, that he began the habit that became his signature: **the long beard**, grown first to cover the disfigurement, kept until it turned white and became the way a whole California town knew him.

The Powder River

When Lee surrendered in the spring of 1865, the 12th Missouri did not go home. On July 1 the regiment marched out of Omaha as the backbone of Col. Nelson Cole's column of the **Powder River Expedition** — some 1,400 Missourians and 140 wagons, sent under Brig. Gen. Patrick Connor's overall command against the Sioux, Cheyenne, and Arapaho of the northern plains. The column crossed 560 miles of the Loup country and the badlands before it ever reached the Powder, and its supplies failed long before its enemies appeared.

This chapter of Thomas's life reached the family through a historian's pen: in the published work of Arroyo Grande's Jim Gregory, the compiler of this history read that Thomas's column *had to circle their wagons because they were pinned down by Indians*. The military record says exactly that. From September 1 to 8, 1865, Cole's column fought a running series of engagements on the Powder — a dawn strike on the horse herd at Alkali Creek, then, on September 8, an attack by some 2,500 warriors, fought off from the corralled wagon train with artillery. That night a freezing storm killed hundreds of the starving horses, and the Adjutant General's memorandum records without ceremony that the men "eat mule and horse meat." Here, too, belongs the family record's most harrowing scene: Thomas's detachment surrounded, his horse and a comrade's shot down in the first volley, the two fighting on foot from behind their fallen mounts "as bullets tore through the tall grass around them," holding until their comrades broke through — and days later, starving, eating what remained of those horses. San Luis Obispo County newspapers retold it for decades. And the story has a second witness in the ground: the Arroyo Grande historian Jim Gregory identifies **James Anias Dowell**, a trooper of the 16th Kansas Cavalry on the same expedition, as Keown's comrade — "and here are the two old soldiers at rest," Gregory writes, "and not far from each other, in the Arroyo Grande District Cemetery." Two Powder River survivors, neighbors in life and in death.

And Gregory's 2016 account of the expedition adds a scene almost beyond believing — witnessed from behind those same corralled wagons. Cole's column had blundered into the country between the camps of Sitting Bull and Red Cloud, and on September 8, as the warriors tried to draw the soldiers out from their wagon square, a lone rider made a "dare ride" along the barricade — in Gregory's words, "a warrior, nearly nude except for moccasins and breechclout, with his light, slightly curly hair tied back, with a small stone behind his ear fixed in place by a leather strap." **His name was Crazy Horse**. Behind him rode Roman Nose in his eagle-feather war bonnet, on a white horse that was shot from under him. The troopers held their fire and held their square, answering three attacks with carbines and canister. Thomas Keown, twenty years from his walnut trees, looked out over a wagon tongue at the two most famous warriors of the Plains.

Gregory's account, as recalled from that reading, also included a rescue — one soldier slipping away through the lines to bring help. The expedition's official record runs the rescue the other way, and this paper gives both versions honestly until Gregory's exact text is back in hand. General Connor, alarmed by his lost columns' silence, sent scouting parties into the Powder River country; on **September 13** his Pawnee scouts found the starving command and turned it toward Fort Connor. A Cheyenne witness said you could follow Cole's trail "from the carcass of one Missouri horse or mule to the next." On September 20 the column staggered into the fort — shoeless, in rags, judged unfit for further service. Of the 263 men the 12th Missouri lost in its whole existence, 227 died not of bullets but of disease and hardship, and much of that price was paid on the Powder.

The regiment wintered on the frontier in the Fort Laramie country and mustered out at last on **April 9, 1866** — a year to the day after Appomattox. It rode back into St. Louis, in the family history's words, "a weary and depleted regiment... but they carried a sense of grim pride. They had done what was asked of them and pushed farther west than most soldiers of their time." Thomas Keown was twenty years old, and he had already been to war twice.

One search continues: the compiler recalls reading Thomas referenced by name in published accounts of the Plains Indian Wars. The day-by-day histories of Cole's column — Wagner's Powder River Odyssey above all — quote enlisted men by name from their diaries, and the hunt through their indexes is under way. If he is there, a future edition will quote him.

Greentop, and Phoebe

Home in north Missouri, the young veteran found the other half of his life. On **June 14, 1870, at Greentop, Missouri**, Thomas married **Phoebe Ellen McKinney** — a partnership that would last sixty-three years. (Phoebe's own family carried its griefs from the same war years: her father, Gideon McKinney, died in 1865.) Then began the long westering that so many veteran families made: Missouri, then the farms of Concordia, Kansas; Nebraska in 1883; a spell in Arkansas; then back to the Nebraska sandhills country — where the G.A.R. rolls carry Thomas in **Post 223 of Sheridan County** (Rushville, later Gordon), and where the 1893 state listings record a "T. Keown" as an *officer* of the Hay Springs post, meeting every other Saturday at two o'clock. And at last, on **March 3, 1897**, the wagon road's end at **Arroyo Grande, California**. They moved into their four-acre ranch the next day — the very day William McKinley was inaugurated — and Thomas set about planting the walnut and fruit trees that would feed the family for decades.

The father went west first

Here the 2026 research overturned what this paper's first edition assumed — that Nathan's story faded out in Missouri after his discharge. It did not. The county history of San Luis Obispo, published in 1917, records that when Arroyo Grande's Grand Army post — **Colonel Harper Post No. 126** — was instituted on **June 25, 1880**, one of its ten charter members was **Nathan J. Keown**. The broken sergeant of the 21st

Missouri had crossed the continent: he was in Arroyo Grande seventeen years before Thomas arrived. When Thomas rolled in by wagon in 1897, he was not discovering new country. He was following his father.

“Sergeant Nathan J. Keown, Co. B, 21st Missouri, was a charter member and father of Thomas H. Keown, who served in Co. F, 12th Missouri... Father and son fought shoulder to shoulder to preserve intact their country and ours.”

MORRISON & HAYDON, HISTORY OF SAN LUIS OBISPO COUNTY AND ENVIRONS, 1917

One honest note on that fine sentence: “shoulder to shoulder” is the county historian’s flourish, not the muster rolls’. The service cards show father and son in different regiments in different years — Nathan discharged ten months before Thomas enlisted. They fought for the same cause; they never fought in the same line. Two smaller threads from the same records still need pulling: a *Mahelda Keown* stands among the 1883 charter members of the Arroyo Grande Woman’s Relief Corps — quite possibly Nathan’s wife, though no record yet says so — and a Nebraska G.A.R. index carries an “N.G. Keown, 21st Mo Inf” in the Ord post, organized 1882, which reads like Nathan following the family out to Nebraska for a stretch of the 1880s. Where and when Nathan died, and where he lies, is now the paper’s foremost open question — and if it is anywhere near Arroyo Grande, there is a grave to visit.

The ranch on the Arroyo

Thomas and Phoebe raised six children and buried two infant sons. Four daughters lived to carry the line: **Bertha** (Mrs. Perry, of Gordon, Nebraska), **Mary** (Mrs. Kenyon, of Stockton), **Ethel** (Mrs. Ball), and **Edna** — Mrs. Schultz of Orcutt, this family’s own line. The ranch became the family’s gathering place, filled on birthdays and anniversaries “with laughter and conversation.” Phoebe served as president of the Women’s Relief Corps, the G.A.R. auxiliary, honored for decades of service to veterans and their families. Arroyo Grande came to call the two of them “beloved pioneers.”

An act of Congress

In his sixties, the old trooper’s service was recognized in the most formal way the Republic had. In April 1910, California’s Representative Sylvester C. Smith introduced **H.R. 24932**, a bill granting an increase of pension to Thomas H. Keown; its substance was enacted in the great omnibus pension act signed on **January 27, 1911**. On page 1899 of volume 36 of the United States Statutes at Large, between the names of other aging soldiers, stands this family’s line:

UNITED STATES STATUTES AT LARGE · ACT OF JAN. 27, 1911, CH. 30		36 Stat. 1899
PROVISION	<i>“The name of Thomas H. Keown, late of Company F, Twelfth Regiment Missouri Volunteer Cavalry, and pay him a pension at the rate of twenty-four dollars per month in lieu of that he is now receiving.”</i>	
SPONSOR	Rep. Sylvester C. Smith of California · H.R. 24932, 61st Congress	

Twenty-four dollars a month — and his name, rank, and regiment printed in the permanent laws of the United States. The family remembered this rightly: Congress passed legislation with Thomas Keown’s name in it.

The last man of the Fred Steele Post

Thomas remained, all his long life, a soldier among soldiers. Arroyo Grande’s own post was his father’s — Colonel Harper Post No. 126 — and as its generation thinned, the county’s veterans consolidated into **Fred Steele Post No. 70 of San Luis Obispo**, named for the Union major general whose brothers helped build the county. By the 1930s that post’s membership had dwindled to a handful, then to one. When Thomas Henderson Keown died on **May 2, 1933**, at eighty-six, he was the post’s last surviving member — and under G.A.R. rules, his death dissolved it. The Civil War era of San Luis Obispo County formally ended with him that week.

He had prepared for it. Before his death, Thomas personally handed the post’s time-worn flags and historic documents to the local Spanish-American War veterans for safekeeping — one generation of American soldiers passing its colors to the next. The Women’s Relief Corps returned the old charter to national headquarters. His funeral began at the Keown home and moved to the Masonic Hall — he was a Mason as well as a veteran — with Rev. L. C. Routzahn officiating, and ended, as a soldier’s should, with **Taps sounding over Arroyo Grande Cemetery.**

“His death served to drive home dramatically... that the men of that war were leaving us. He was the last.”

AFTER THE TRIBUNE’S COVERAGE, MAY 1933 — THE PAPERS FOLLOWED THE POST’S DISOLUTION FOR TWO WEEKS

Phoebe’s own words

In 2025, the Arroyo Grande historian Jim Gregory republished a page of the *Herald-Recorder* from early 1935, printed the week after Phoebe died at eighty-four — and it carries two treasures this family did not know it had. The first is a **photograph of Thomas and Phoebe together, taken on their fiftieth wedding anniversary** in June 1920: the old cavalryman with the great white beard, Phoebe beside him in her lace collar.

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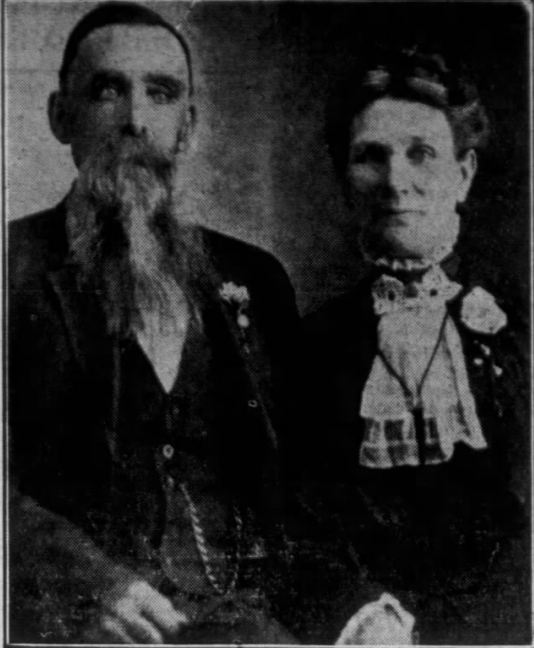
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MR. AND MRS. THOMAS H. KEOWN
(This photograph was taken on their 50th Wedding Anniversary.)

Following is an article written by the late Mrs. Phoebe E. Keown, aged 84 years, who passed away last week and who was the widow of a Veteran of the Grand Army of the Republic.

It is entitled "Fraternity, Charity and Loyalty," and is a beautiful word description of the Grand Army's motto.

"Born of battles and strengthened by the common suffering of years of war for the preservation of the Union, the spirit of comradeship between the men who composed the immense armies of the federal government from 1861 to 1865 has been strong enough to make the organization of the Grand Army of the Republic, composed of Union Veterans, one that is in many respects the most remarkable in history.

"Fraternity, Charity and Loyalty—three words form the foundation on which the tenets of the Grand Army of the Republic are based.

"Fraternity—means the continuance of acquaintances made in camp, on the march and on the fields of battle. A mantle of brotherly love thrown over a warm but fainting heart. A stay for faltering steps, a smile for those who smile, a tear for those who weep and an ear and sympathy for sorrow.

"Charity—means faithful to promises to dying Comrades to care for the dear ones left behind. And the Order is ever ready with the helping hand—not the hand that bestows a tithe of wealth, but, the widow's mite—often their all. The Comrades, as a whole, are not blessed plentifully. Their best life was given to their Country, and with no profession or trade, it is like gathering fragments of the harvest where the reaper has spared little, but the fragments are divided and the pledges carried out.

"Loyalty—this crowning word means, when spoken from the Grand Army standpoint, that ALL that the old soldiers fought for should be maintained. That our Country, great and good, shall be represented from one end to the other by one flag—the Stars and Stripes—Old Glory."

of the Corps presented the Installing Officer with a radio scarf and

JUDGE RUTHERFORD
TO BROADCAST SUN

"Mr. and Mrs. Thomas H. Keown — this photograph was taken on their 50th Wedding Anniversary." Arroyo Grande Herald-Recorder, 1935, republished by Jim Gregory, 2025.

The second is Phoebe's own writing. The paper printed, as her memorial, an essay she had written on the Grand Army's motto — the words of a woman who had presided over the Relief Corps and spent a lifetime beside a veteran:

“Fraternity — means the continuance of acquaintances made in camp, on the march and on the fields of battle. A mantle of brotherly love thrown over a warm but fainting heart. A stay for faltering steps, a smile for those who smile, a tear for those who weep and an ear and sympathy for sorrow... Loyalty — this crowning word means, when spoken from the Grand Army standpoint, that ALL that the old soldiers fought for should be maintained. That our Country, great and good, shall be represented from one end to the other by one flag — the Stars and Stripes — Old Glory.”

PHOEBEE KEOWN, “FRATERNITY, CHARITY AND LOYALTY,” PRINTED AT HER DEATH, ARROYO GRANDE HERALD-RECORDER, 1935

And in the Arroyo Grande District Cemetery, the government stone above her husband says in marble what this paper has said in pages:



Thomas's G.A.R. shield stone, Arroyo Grande District Cemetery: Thomas H. Keown · Co. F · 12 Mo. Cav. · Oct. 25, 1846 – May 2, 1933. His Powder River comrade James A. Dowell (Co. M, 16 Kans. Cav., 1832–1919) lies not far away.

The beard and the little girl

One more witness belongs in this paper, and she is the reason it exists. Among the grandchildren who filled the Arroyo Grande ranch was **Marjorie Schultz of Orcutt** — who grew up to be Marjorie Schultz

Rawson, and whose grandson compiled this history. She remembered, all her life, sitting in Thomas's lap as a small child and running her fingers through the long white beard — the beard grown seventy years earlier to cover an artillery scar — while the old cavalryman smiled and told stories from his youth. A little girl's hands in a soldier's beard: that is how close this family still is to the Civil War. The author of this paper knew and was raised by people who knew Thomas Keown's touch.

The three soldiers, summarized honestly

● **Nathan J. Keown (abt. 1815, Kentucky – after 1882)**

The father. Sergeant, Co. B, 21st Missouri Infantry — enlisted July 6, 1861; Athens (probable), Shiloh, Corinth; discharged for disability Jan. 30, 1863; went west and stood as charter member of Arroyo Grande's G.A.R. post, 1880; death and grave not yet found

■ **John H. Keown (abt. 1845, Kentucky – Apr. 1, 1862, Hannibal, Mo.)**

The older brother. Corporal, Co. B, 21st Missouri Infantry at sixteen, enlisted the same day as his father; died of disease in the Hannibal hospital five days before his regiment opened Shiloh

■ **Thomas Henderson Keown (Oct. 25, 1846, Ohio Co., Kentucky – May 2, 1933, Arroyo Grande)**

The third to serve. Union cavalryman at 17, Co. F, 12th Missouri Cavalry; wounded by artillery; Nashville and the Powder River Expedition; husband of Phoebe for 63 years; last man of the Fred Steele Post, G.A.R.

Evidence note, in this family's standing rule: facts above rest on the 1860 census page, the Missouri State Archives service cards of 2026, the regiments' published histories, the named newspapers of 1933–1935, and the family's compiled history of 2025 with its cited sources. Where a claim rests on tradition or inference — the Keowns' presence at Athens, Nathan's presence in Shiloh's dawn line, Thomas's naming in the Powder River literature — it is labeled as such in the text, and this paper will be corrected as records land. The definitive next documents are the federal Compiled Service Records and Thomas's pension file at the National Archives, now on the order list — and, newly opened by this edition: Nathan's death and burial, and Mahelda Keown's identity.

Sources

1. Robert Babcock, comp., *Thomas Henderson Keown (1846–1933): A Life in War and Peace*, 8 chapters, 2025 — the family's compiled history, drawing on the newspapers cited therein.
2. 1860 U.S. Federal Census, Missouri: household of Nathan J. Keown (dwelling 1047, family 850) — census page image in family research files.
3. Missouri State Archives, Office of the Adjutant General, Record of Service Cards, Civil War: Keown, Nathan J. (Sgt., Co. B, 21st Inf.) and Keown, John H. (Corp., Co. B, 21st Inf.). Box 46, reel s00857, images 0802 and 0801; card images in family files, 2026.
4. Starr & Holman, *The 21st Missouri Regiment Infantry Veteran Volunteers: Historical Memoranda* (1899), embedding Col. Moore's and Lt. Col. Woodyard's Shiloh reports; Dyer, *Compendium of the War of the Rebellion*, 21st Missouri Infantry and 12th Missouri Cavalry entries.
5. Missouri Adjutant General, Annual Report 1865, Historical Memorandum of the 12th Missouri Cavalry (incl. Nashville losses and the "eat mule and horse meat" entry); published accounts of the Powder River Expedition and the September 1865 Powder River battles (Wagner, *Powder River Odyssey*; Hafen, ed., *Powder River Campaigns*; WyoHistory.org) — index search for Thomas by name in progress.

6. *The Tribune* (San Luis Obispo), May 3, 4, 5, 6, and 16, 1933; *Arroyo Grande Valley Herald-Recorder*, Apr. 7, 1933, and Jan. 4, 1935; *Santa Maria Times*, Jan. 3, 1935; *Morning Press* (Santa Barbara) and *Pismo Times*, 1933 — obituary, funeral, and G.A.R. post-dissolution coverage. PDF copies in family research files.
7. Jim Gregory, “Horse Soldiers — From Patriot Graves,” South County Historical Society.
8. DAR Genealogical Research System, Patriot Ancestor A065094 (Thomas Keown, South Carolina); Salley & Wates, *Stub Entries to Indents*, Liber O, no. 557.
9. *Report of the Adjutant General of the State of Kentucky: Soldiers of the War of 1812* (1891), pp. 276–277 — Capt. Thomas Sterrett’s Company: privates Nathan and William Kown, enlisted Nov. 20, 1814.
10. Jerry Long, “Family of George M. Thomas & Sarah Ann Keown” (Owensboro, 1995); Larkin C. Keown, *Genealogy of the Keown Family* (1908), Daviess County Public Library, Owensboro.
11. Marriage of Thomas H. Keown and Phoebe Ellen McKinney, June 14, 1870, Greentop, Missouri, per the compiled history; 1910 Congressional Record pension entry referenced therein.
12. Morrison & Haydon, *History of San Luis Obispo County and Environs, California, with Biographical Sketches* (1917), pp. 171–173 — Colonel Harper Post No. 126 roster and charter members; Fred Steele Post No. 70; Woman’s Relief Corps charter (Mahelda Keown); the “shoulder to shoulder” passage.
13. Act of January 27, 1911, ch. 30 (omnibus pension act), 61st Congress — Thomas H. Keown provision at 36 Stat. 1899; H.R. 24932 introduced by Rep. Sylvester C. Smith of California, April 1910.
14. Jim Gregory, “To the Historians of the Powder River Country, from Central California,” *A Work in Progress* (blog), Sept. 16, 2025 — Keown and James Anias Dowell as Powder River survivors, drawing on the *Arroyo Grande Herald-Recorder*, 1935; and Gregory, “How NOT to Fight Indians,” same blog, Mar. 4, 2016 — the Cole column narrative naming Dowell and Keown, the September 8 wagon-square fight, and the Crazy Horse dare ride.
- 14a. *San Luis Obispo Daily Telegram*, May 3, 1933, five o’clock edition: “Arroyo G.A.R. Veteran Dies — County Loses Pioneer — Pioneer Family Broken,” with the 59th-anniversary photograph of Thomas and Phoebe (June 1929) — obituary stating birth in Ohio County, Kentucky, the 1870 marriage at Greentop, the Concordia–Nebraska–Arkansas migration, and the March 3, 1897 arrival at Arroyo Grande. Clipping image in family research files.
15. Sherard, comp., *Nebraska Civil War G.A.R. Members Index* (Denver Public Library): Thomas H. Keown, 12th Mo. Cav., Post 223 (Rushville/Gordon); “T. Keown,” Hay Springs post officer, 1893; “N.G. Keown, 21st Mo. Inf.,” Post 40 (Ord).
16. San Luis Obispo County Farm Bureau centennial booklet: Arroyo Grande charter signer list, Oct. 18, 1916, incl. Thomas H. Keown.
17. Family oral history: recollections of Marjorie Schultz Rawson, as preserved by her grandson.

All records cited are attached (or being attached) to the corresponding people in the Robert Babcock Family Tree on Ancestry, where the original document images can be viewed.

*For Nathan, who marched first; for John, who gave everything at sixteen;
and for Thomas, who came home, planted trees, and let a little girl pull his beard.*